# "All Creation Rejoices in You": Creation in the Liturgies for the Feasts of the Theotokos

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## Introduction

Transfiguration is at the very core of Orthodox liturgy. It is well known that the notion of *theosis* as the transfiguring and deifying of believers is the central redemptive thrust of Eastern theology. This belief and goal is expressed and made real in liturgical practice. Yet such transfiguring does not apply only to the human person. Rather, the liturgy takes up and transforms all of creation, including the very space and time in which it takes place.[1] Increasingly, Orthodox scholars are recognizing the potential of this insight for the ecological debate. In fact, a phrase from the Eucharistic action of the liturgy is used most often to confirm Orthodox valuing of all creation: "Thine own of Thine own, we offer unto Thee, on behalf of all and for all." Patriarch Bartholomew I, the Ecumenical Patriarch, uses this phrase to point to the ecological potential of Orthodox faith:

> In the bread and wine of the Eucharist, as priests standing before the altar of the world, we offer creation back to the Creator in the context of a mutual relationship to Him and to each other. We celebrate the beauty of creation and consecrate the life of the world, returning it to God with thanks. We share the world in joy as a living mystical communion with the Divine. Thus we offer the fullness of creation at the Eucharist, and receive it back as a blessing, as the living presence of God.[2]

His many addresses and activities on behalf of environmental action have earned him the title "Green Patriarch."[3] Other Orthodox thinkers have taken up this challenge and explored further how Orthodox faith might

express concern for creation and the environment.[4] In this discussion, the human function as offering the entire creation to God Eucharistically is frequently cited as the central Orthodox insight.[5] Yet rarely do authors go beyond these more general statements to show how Orthodox liturgy more generally might support or give rise to an ecological theology or to injunctions for ecological action. The greater ecological potential of the Liturgy remains unexplored.

Yet the Eastern Liturgy has a great wealth of images, statements, and actions that can inform a more ecologically conscious worldview, namely one that sees nonhuman creation as valuable and as a real partner in sharing the planet, instead of as a resource to be exploited in purely utilitarian fashion for our own benefit. And while a "cosmic" role of human beings is occasionally indicated in the Liturgy, it is far from being the only way in which an examination of the Liturgy can contribute to the conversation. Rather, close attention to liturgical texts and practices shows all of creation as sacred and hallowed by the Spirit, as affected by sin, as redeemed in Christ, and as a full participant in the worship of God (and possibly even in deification). While the liturgy itself does not develop all of these themes in a systematic theological fashion, its wealth of images and affirmations provides sufficient material for making such theological statements explicit and developing their ecological implications.[6] The most obvious liturgical locus for developing theological statements with ecological intent is probably the service of Theophany. It has indeed been used as an example repeatedly, and although it has not been explicated and interpreted as fully as it deserves, certainly more attention has been focused on it than on any other liturgical service in the Eastern tradition.[7] Let me therefore analyze liturgical texts that have not yet received any such attention, namely the services celebrating the feasts of the Theotokos.[8]

## The Feasts of the Theotokos

As is true of Orthodox iconography and theology more generally, feasts of the Theotokos usually focus on the Incarnation. There are very few statements about Mary in Orthodox theology that constitute theological Marian reflection disconnected from her role in the Incarnation. Jaroslav Pelikan points out the great role Mary plays even within the regular Liturgy.[9] He examines in detail the various phrases of the Sunday morning Liturgy that mention the Theotokos and shows that veneration of the Theotokos is not in competition with worship of Christ but that she is honored as the first of saints who has become holy, even as we are to live holy Christian lives as well. Joseph Nasrallah, a Roman Catholic thinker who has analyzed Mary's

place in the Byzantine liturgy, also examines the "ordinary" Liturgy celebrated every Sunday morning, highlighting various antiphons used within this liturgy.[10] He then goes on to consider briefly fourteen feasts and commemorations of the Theotokos, pointing out that the church year begins with a commemoration of the Theotokos on September 1 and ends with a similar feast of her on August 31.[11] Her feasts therefore frame the church year. Although Nasrallah cites only isolated portions of these feasts and commemorations, and his primary point in this treatment is to justify the immaculate conception, almost all of the texts he cites refer to creation in some way.[12] He begins his treatment of the role of the Theotokos in the Liturgy by emphasizing, as we have seen above, that for the Eastern tradition the Liturgy is the place where the new heaven and earth are present, where all creatures assemble around their creator.[13] In a reflection on Mary's place in the liturgy, Paul Doncoeur similarly points out that "creation can have no other end than the glory of God" and that this is expressed within the liturgy.[14] Redemption means to restore to the cosmos this voice that has been silenced by the fall of Satan and Adam. He claims that the feasts of the Theotokos show Mary in particular as the one who most fully performs this glorification of God in her life and song and draws all of creation (including the angels) into the praise of liturgical worship.[15] It is also interesting that nature is particularly associated with Marian feasts in other ways. In some areas, imprisoned birds are freed on the Feast of the Annunciation to signify the freedom and restoration of creation begun at this inception of the Incarnation.[16] At the Feast of the Dormition in August, flowers are often blessed.[17] It seems that the larger creation is not a peripheral theme in these feasts.

Three different aspects of creation can be detected within the liturgies of these feasts and can be read as making important contributions for an ecological theology: (a) the intimate connection between creation and redemption in the texts, (b) the strong emphasis on the participation of "all of creation" in rejoicing over the incarnation, and (c) the implication that the Incarnation has cosmic significance and is accomplished for all of creation. It would also be possible to consider the imagery employed for Mary herself, who serves as an "icon" of creation and is often compared to the earth, but this final point carries so much contentious baggage that it will not be explored here as an important contribution to ecological theology.[18]

## Creation and Incarnation

Creation and Incarnation are linked in a dual fashion in these feasts. On the one hand, Christ's birth as a human being in the Incarnation and his

materiality are emphasized. On the other hand, the Incarnation refers back to the Creator and affirms the essential connection between incarnation and creation.

First, the Incarnation, and in particular Mary's role within it, are read as affirmations of matter. Even in the theological tradition Christ's real birth from Mary is often cited as a warning against various sorts of Docetist or Gnostic heresies that do not take seriously Christ's embrace of flesh and matter by becoming incarnate within them. Mary is affirmed to be giving human flesh and created materiality to Christ.[19] She is celebrated primarily for her role as the "Mother of God," and the feasts honoring her employ this language throughout.[20] The essential materiality of the Incarnation is emphasized throughout: "The Word who before was wholly outside matter, in these last times has assumed the material substance of the flesh."[21] Great stress is placed on Mary's "material womb," as in the Feast of her Nativity.[22] The following ode affirms: "It is she who shall bear unto us the Word, appearing in the material substance of the flesh" (121). Mary is consistently depicted as the one who gives flesh to the divine: "and I shall bear Him that is without flesh, who shall borrow flesh from me."[23] Christ's becoming flesh is understood as a kenotic humbling, with frequent reference to diapers: "O Sun, my Son, how shall I wrap Thee in swaddling clothes? How shall I give Thee milk, who givest food to all creation? How shall I hold Thee in my arms who holdest all things?"[24] In the feast of the Nativity, the wise men are affirmed to have been "amazed to see neither sceptre nor throne but only utter poverty. For what is meaner than a cave, what is humbler than swaddling clothes? Yet therein shone forth the wealth of Thy divinity."[25] Christ's incarnation accomplishes salvation by uniting heaven and earth, which had been split apart by the Fall. This is particularly obvious in the liturgy for the feast of the Nativity of Christ: "Heaven and earth are united today, for Christ is born. Today has God come upon the earth, and man gone up to heaven. Today for man's sake is seen in the flesh He who by nature is invisible . . ."[26] That this is indeed put in the context of creation is also supported by the fact that the first reading for the Office of the Nativity (just as for Pascha and Theophany) is Genesis 1.[27]

Second, the language of Incarnation employed in these feasts strongly emphasizes creation. God or the Trinity are consistently referred to as "Creator," and there is much imagery that contrasts the "creation" of Christ's human flesh with his being the Creator. Often this is put in an explicit paradox, as during Vespers for the feast of the Nativity:

> Triumph, O Zion; make glad, O Jerusalem, city of Christ our God: receive the Creator who is contained within a cave and a manger. Open

> unto me the gates, and entering within I shall see as a child wrapped in swaddling clothes Him who upholds the creation in the hollow of His hand, whose praises the angels sing with unceasing voice, the Lord and Giver of Life who saves mankind. (203)

The Sixth Hour on the Feast of the Nativity affirms that "our God and Creator has clothed Himself in created flesh, and He who with His strong arm fashioned the creation reveals Himself in the womb of her that He formed" (238). It is repeatedly said in various of the festal liturgies that the Creator is "fashioned as a creature."[28]

Throughout these texts, the entire Trinity is frequently referred to as "Master of Creation." Yet quite often, Christ is explicitly identified as the Creator: "The Creator, having become a young child without undergoing change, has reshaped according to the form of His divinity our nature, taken from the earth and destined to return to earth once more."[29] At times, Christ as Creator is even placed in contrast to the Father because he identifies more fully with creation through the Incarnation: "The Master, by His coming in the flesh, has cut clean through the harsh enmity of the flesh against Him, and has destroyed the might of the murderer of our souls. Uniting the world to the immaterial essences, He has made the Father merciful to the creation."[30]

Patristic homilies similarly stress the Incarnation and its affirmation of the material world. John of Damascus sees all of creation connected to God through the Incarnation.[31] Gregory Nazianzen makes an explicit link between creation and redemption in an early homily: "This is the origin of the nativity and of the virgin, the origin of the manger and of Bethlehem. The creation explains the nativity; the woman explains the virgin. The rationale for Bethlehem is Eden; the rationale for the manger is paradise. What is great and hidden is shown by what is little and visible."[32] He expresses the condescension or *kenosis* of the Incarnation, which sanctifies the most lowly aspects of nature, in beautiful terms:

> When he teaches on a mountain, when he converses in the plain, when he passes into a boat, when he reprimands the tempests. He accepts sleep without doubt in order to sanctify sleep; he weeps without doubt in order to render tears praiseworthy. He passes from one place to another, he who is contained in no place, he who is outside of time, who has no body, who is not circumscribed by limits.[33]

Christ's condescension in the Incarnation is a full embrace of the material condition. Hesychius of Jerusalem actually refers to the Feast of the Purification

(or the Meeting) as the "feast of feasts" or the "most holy feast among the holy feasts" because

> it recapitulates in fact the entire mystery of the Incarnation of Christ, it describes the entire presentation of the only Son. In this feast, Christ was carried as a new-born and confessed as God, the creator of our nature has been offered in the arms as seated on a throne, and he offered a couple of spiritual turtledoves to Symeon and Anna.[34]

He continues in language relying on Isaiah 40:12 and also employed by the liturgical texts: "He carried in his hands him who holds in his hand the inhabited and uninhabited earth, 'he who has measured the water in his hand, the heavens with a span and the entire earth in a measure'" (I.5, 35). For a different Marial feast, Hesychius imagines the Magi asking questions about the paradoxical nature of the miracle of Christ's birth:

> How does he who is perfect become a newborn? How does he who nourishes (the world) suck milk? How is he who embraces the universe enclosed in arms? How is "the Father of the age to come" become a baby? How does he who is on high find himself also below? How can he who is in the heavens be also on earth? . . . How can "he who is in the womb of the Father" be in a crib? (VI.4, 199)

Here the same contrast between mighty creator and creaturely weakness is juxtaposed, as in the Liturgy. Germanos, in a homily on the Annunciation, also draws an explicit connection between creation and redemption:

> Hail, favored one, who caused the Sun that is eternal to arise for the world in flesh, [a Sun] who dazzled the whole of creation with his goodness! Hail, favored one, the all-bright cloud of the life-giving Spirit, which carries the rain of compassion and sprinkles all creation! Hail, favored one, salvation of those born on earth, who transformed grief into joy, and joined the things on earth with those in heaven, and who loosed the dividing walls of enmity![35]

He continues by hailing Mary in various natural imagery by presenting a long dialogue between the angel and the Theotokos, where she only slowly assents (in contrast to Eve, who quickly agrees to eat the fruit), followed by a dialogue between Mary and Joseph. He concludes with another connection between incarnation and paradise, creation and new creation: "This one, the ever flourishing and incorruptible paradise, in which the Tree of life was planted and produced without hindrance the fruit of immortality for everyone! This one, a bringing forth of the new creation in which the water of life

gushes!" (245). Ephrem the Syrian, in a homily on the Nativity, employs the same sorts of contrasts: "He who measures the heavens with the span of his hand / lies in a manger a span's breadth; / He whose cupped hands contain the sea / is born in a cave; / His glory fills the heavens / and the manger is filled with His splendor" (lines 28–34, 63).[36] Proclus employs similar language in a homily on the same subject:

> Let me utter the mystery! / Though he is God, "he appeared on earth" (Bar. 3:38), / and came to dwell through the virgin where he was present. / And the birth did not belittle him, / and the birth pains did not change his uncreated nature, / but created form gave a form to the Creator, / and the world contained the uncontainable when he became flesh, / when he became man without sin. (2.4, 73)[37]

In an *Encomium on the Dormition* attributed (probably falsely) to Modestus, Mary is presented as life and spring of the world because the "fountainhead of the universe" was born of her. The homilist concludes that Christ "has, through her, set creation free from slavery, and has brought into reality surpassing joy for the whole cosmos."[38] These themes of joy and liberation of the cosmos are evident also in the liturgical texts themselves.[39]

Creation and Incarnation are, then, closely linked to each other. It is the Creator who becomes incarnate as a creature. This incarnation is an affirmation of the flesh and of matter.[40] Christ has a truly material body, and his birth from a human mother confirms his full identification with the creation. Yet while an emphasis on flesh and materiality is certainly important for a more positive attitude toward nature, it does not yet explicitly affirm that this goes beyond an affirmation of *human* flesh and materiality. What role, if any, do other creatures play in these liturgies?

## All Creatures Praise God

Creation actually has a significant role within the Liturgy as participating in the worship of God and the veneration of the Theotokos. In countless repetitions, creation is said to "glorify" or "bring praises" either to God for the miracle of the feast or even to the Theotokos herself. The idea that all of creation rejoices is a constant theme: "Therefore in praise let us sing: Let the whole creation bless the Lord and exalt him above all for ever."[41] The Forefeast of the Nativity similarly exhorts: "Let the creation rejoice exceedingly: for the Creator now makes Himself to be created, and He who was before all things now makes Himself known as God newly revealed."[42] Often, Christ's descending into creation is linked to creation's celebration of this mystery, as

is especially the case for the Nativity liturgies: "Thou hast made the whole creation shine with joy. All that hath breath praises Thee, the Image of the glory of the Father."[43] Here it is already implied that Christ's mission extends to all of creation, something that will be explored further below. Yet the participation of all of creation in praise of God is explicit. Some contemporary thinkers seek to dismiss this language as purely metaphorical. Theokritoff has suggested that this would be a mistake and that the participation of non-human creatures in praise of God should be taken more literally.[44]

Indeed, the praise of creation suffuses the liturgical texts. Sometimes the phrase "Let the whole creation bless the Lord and exalt Him above all for ever" is used as a refrain, similar to the way in which it is employed by the Song of the Three Children.[45] Creation joins in praise with the Theotokos, the saints, and the assembled people. The Ikos for Matins on the Synaxis of the Theotokos makes this particularly clear: "Therefore all of creation shares in my joy and cries to me: Hail, thou who art full of grace" (293). The whole world joins together in song: "today all creation greatly rejoices. . . . Today the proud insolence of the serpent is brought low, for the fetters of the curse laid on our forefathers are loosened. Therefore with all the world we cry aloud to thee: Hail, thou who art full of grace."[46] The creation glorifies not merely God but also Mary. She is the one "whose praises all creation sings."[47] The creation rejoices in her birth as it does in that of the Creator because it renews all of creation.[48] Over and over it is affirmed that "the whole creation calls thee blessed."[49]

In some texts one might imagine that "all of creation" stands as a shorthand way of saying "all humans."[50] Yet often that is clearly not the case in these feasts, as various specific beings and parts of creation are explicitly named, such as "the heavens" (referring here to the sky, not the abode of God or angels), "the seas," "mountains, hills, hollows, rivers and seas, and the whole creation," "all the earth," "every creature," and "the depths" (probably including "Sheol," the abode of the dead). Earth and sea rejoice: "Be joyful, all the earth . . . Be glad, O sea . . ."[51] Heaven and earth join equally into song: "Greatly rejoice, O heaven; be glad, O earth."[52] Mountains and rivers celebrate together with human dignitaries: "Let the kings of the whole earth sing rejoicing, and let the companies of the nations be in exceeding joy. Mountains and hills and hollows, rivers and seas, and the whole creation, magnify the Lord who now is born."[53] Various celestial bodies also sing: "the sun sings Thy praises, the moon gives Thee glory, every creature offers its hymn unto Thee, its Author and Creator, for ever."[54] Furthermore, in the Feast of the Nativity, various parts of creation (including humans) are imagined as contributing gifts to celebrate Christ's birth:

> What shall we offer Thee, O Christ, who for our sake hast appeared on earth as man? Every creature made by Thee offers Thee thanks. The angels offer Thee a hymn; the heavens a star; the Magi, gifts; the shepherds, their wonder; the earth, its cave; the wilderness, the manger; and we offer Thee a Virgin Mother.[55]

And, indeed, not only does the whole of creation participate in praise, but the manner of this rejoicing is depicted in vivid detail. Creation is portrayed as praising, singing, "leaping with joy," clapping hands, "rejoicing exceedingly and raising its voice," "keeping feast," "blessing the Lord," "being amazed," "rejoicing greatly," even "dancing."[56] This is not just mentioned once or twice but is instead a strong theme in all the texts. Creation clearly plays a role in the Liturgy, and God enjoys its praise. One might even suggest that human praise is guided by this prior praise of nature. "Heaven, earth, and the depths stand in awe of Thee, men bless Thee, fire is Thy servant, all things created obey Thee in fear, O Holy Trinity."[57] Various creatures hence play an active role in the glorification of God accomplished within the liturgy. All creatures join together in the liturgical chorus.

Again, this rejoicing of creation in the liturgical texts is confirmed by many homilies. In fact, this is probably the strongest theme in the Patristic homilies on Mary. In a *Homily on the Nativity* (still called Theophany at the time), Gregory Nazianzen exhorts his audience to join the animals and other figures in the nativity story in gratitude:

> Venerate the manger, at which you, an animal without reason were nourished by the Word. Like an ox, recognize your owner . . . like an ass, know the manger of the Lord himself: whether you are one of the clean beasts, subject to the Law, who chew on the cud of the word and are fit for sacrifice, or whether you are still unclean and unsuited to be food or victim, from the Gentile race. Run with the star; bring gifts, with the Magi, of gold and frankincense and myrrh—gifts for your king, for your God, for the one who became a corpse for your sake! Give glory with the shepherds, sing praise with the angels, dance with the company of archangels! Let there be a common festival for the powers of heaven and earth! For I believe that they, too, are rejoicing and holding festival along with us today, if it is true that they are friends of both humanity and God.[58]

Proclus also imagines the various actors who offer praise in a nativity homily, including explicitly various nonhuman participants together with

the human characters in the story. Proclus at times attributes the activity of "offering" certain human characters to the nonhuman ones:

> Today the unsown seed sprouted forth from the field not cultivated,
> and the famished world rejoices.
> Today a birth without intercourse blossomed forth from the womb without birth pains
> and the whole of creation offers gifts to the fatherless child:
> the earth offers the manger;
> the rocks offer the water urns of stone;
> the mountains offer the cavern;
> the cities offer Bethlehem;
> the winds offer obedience,
> the sea offers subjection,
> the waves offer calmness;
> the depths offer the fishes;
> the fishes offer the water;
> the waters offer the Jordan;
> the fountains offer the woman from Samaria;
> the desert offers John;
> the beasts offer the foal;
> the birds offer the dove;
> the magi offer the gifts;
> the women offer Martha;
> the widows offer Anna;
> the barren women offer Elizabeth;
> the virgins offer Mary, the Birthgiver of God;
> the shepherds offer the chanting of hymns;
> the priests offer Symeon;
> the children offer the palm branches;
> the persecutors offer Paul;
> the sinners offer the tax-collector;
> the pagans offer the Canaanite woman;
> the woman with an issue of blood offers faith;
> the harlot offers the perfume;
> the trees offer Zaccheus;
> the wood offers the cross;
> the cross offers the robber;
> the East offers the star;
> the air offers the cloud;
> heaven offers the angels
> Gabriel offers the greeting . . .[59]

In fact, Proclus often refers to the praise of all of creation. In his *Homily* 24 ("On the Nativity of Our Lord Jesus Christ"), he employs the phrase "let heaven rejoice from above" (quoted from Ps. 71:6) as a sort of repeated refrain for a good section of the homily.[60] John of Damascus exhorts earth and mountains to rejoice: "Acclaim the Lord, all the earth, sing, exult, play instruments!" (6.61); "Jump with joy, mountains" (6.61).[61] In fact, John frequently invites creation to join in praise in his Marian homilies.[62] Andrew of Crete also often speaks of the rejoicing of all of creation. In his first *Homily on the Nativity of the Theotokos* he says:

> Let all creation therefore sing and dance and let it introduce with this something of those things worthy of the day! Let there be one common festival today of heavenly and earthly things and let every compound structure[63] that exists both on earth and in a heavenly manner join in the feasting! For today the created precinct of the Creator of all things has been established, and the creature is newly prepared as divine abode for the Creator. Today the nature that was formerly turned to earth takes on the beginning of deification, and the dust that has been exalted is urged to return to the glory that is on high. Today Adam, presenting [her] out of us and on our behalf as first-fruit to God, dedicates Mary, she indeed who was not mixed with the whole dough; through her bread is made for the remodeling of the grace.

In the third homily, he exhorts heaven to be glad and tells the earth to dance, claiming that the earth has been raised by Mary's pregnancy as the water is sanctified by Christ's baptism. He reiterates, "so then, let all creation rejoice and dance and clap its hands!" In his third homily on the Dormition, he similarly invites heaven and earth to join in song.[64] Theodore the Studite, in an *Encomium on the Dormition*, has "the whole of creation jump for joy" and describes Mary as a life-giving spring for the whole creation.[65] John of Thessalonika, in one of the earliest homilies on the Dormition, connects the praise of creation with its renewal in the Incarnation:

> A fitting hymn of honor, praise and glory is always due, from every creature under heaven, to that remarkable, all-glorious and truly great mistress of all the world, the ever-virgin Mother of our Savior and God Jesus Christ. She is truly the God-bearer, and through her all creation has received, by God's saving plan, the great gift of the presence in the flesh of the only Son and Word of God the Father.[66]

Jacob of Serug beautifully imagines the praise of various creatures in a homily on the Dormition:

> The evil demons were disturbed and agitated,
> for they saw the sign which only happened because of our Lord.
> They saw heaven discharging multitudes of hosts
> and the air was utterly sanctified with sweet fragrance.
> New sounds were heard from all the birds;
> where they were chanting in ranks according to their natures.
> All living creatures made a joyful sound of praise in their places;
> all the earth was stirred by their shouts of joy.
> The heavens and the mountains and all the plains which were adorned,
> broke forth in praise when the virginal body was being laid in the grave.
> All living creatures made a joyful sound of praise in their places;
> all the earth was stirred by their shouts of joy.
> All trees with their fruits and produce
> were sprinkled with drew, the sweet fragrance of their gladness.
> All the flowers which were beautiful in their variety, sent forth perfume like sweet spices sending forth fragrance.
> The waters and the fish and all creeping things within the sea,
> were aware of this day and were moved to praise.
> All creatures silent or eloquent,
> according to their natures rendered the praise which was due.[67]

Thus in many Patristic texts individual nonhuman creatures participate in and respond to the events of the Incarnation. The homilists draw on biblical texts to personify various aspects of creation but also elaborate on this imagery creatively. In these homilies, the whole cosmos is painted as actively engaged in God's praise and has a vested interest in the mystery of the Incarnation.[68]

What is this cosmic significance? Kallistos Ware suggests in his introduction to the Festal Liturgies (in regard to the feast of the Nativity of the Theotokos) that it refers to the redemption of all of creation: "In Mary's case, however, the parents' rejoicing is shared by all creation, for her birth foreshadows the universal salvation that is to come."[69] What do the liturgies say about such a cosmic view of redemption?

## Cosmic Redemption

The Liturgy does indeed suggest that the Incarnation has an impact on all of creation. Creation is changed by it and restored to full communion with God. Not just humans are redeemed but all of creation. There are several dif-

ferent ways in which this can be said to be the case. First, the Incarnation is seen as a new beginning for all of life. The world has been renewed already in the birth of the Theotokos as it anticipates Christ's birth and redemption: "She is born and with her is the whole world become new again."[70] This eschatological imagery is also present in the Feast of the Annunciation. Although here Christ's becoming flesh is celebrated, Mary is also hailed as the one in whom creation is renewed.[71]

Second, the Incarnation (and the Theotokos in particular) are said to "join earth and heaven." The imagery of a bridge is often used, and heaven is described as "bending down" and touching the earth.[72] This causes "things on earth to be set right" and sanctified. This language is especially strong in the Feast of the Dormition, where the Theotokos is affirmed to be the "first-fruits" of creation having reached the Eschaton in some fashion:

> What spiritual songs shall we now offer thee, O most holy? For by thy deathless Dormition thou hast sanctified the whole world, and then has been translated to the places above the world, there to perceive the beauty of the Almighty and, as His Mother, to rejoice in it exceedingly.[73]

The Dormition transfigures the world and restores it to life.[74] She is the "earthly Heaven" who brings together both earth and heaven:

> Come, O ye people, and gaze in wonder: for the holy Mountain of the Lord, in the sight of all, is exalted above the hills of heaven. The earthly Heaven takes up her dwelling in a heavenly and imperishable land.[75]

At times the connection between praise and redemption is made explicit:

> At thy glorious Dormition the heavens rejoice and the armies of angels exult; the whole earth makes glad, singing a hymn of departure to thee, O Mother of Him who is Lord of all . . . "Hail, thou bearer of the whole divinity: hail, thou who alone by thy childbirth hast brought together earthly things and things on high." . . . By thy holy Dormition, O Virgin Mother and Bride of God, thou who gavest birth to the Life hast been transported into immortal life, attended by angels, principalities, and powers, by apostles, prophets, and the whole creation.[76]

Similar language is used in the Feast of the Annunciation:

> Lo, our restoration is now made manifest to us: God is ineffably united to men. At the words of the Archangel error is laid low; for the Virgin receives joy, and the things of the earth have become heaven. The world

> is loosened from the ancient curse. Let the creation rejoice exceedingly and raise its voice to sing: O Lord, our Maker and Deliverer, glory to Thee.[77]

The creation rejoices precisely because earth and heaven have been joined and are again in harmony with each other.

On occasion, it is explicitly affirmed that "the whole creation is made new and godlike," always linked with the earth's rejoicing in this renewal. Mary is made manifest "through whom things on earth are joined with heaven." Consequently (and repeatedly), "today is the beginning of joy for all the world."[78]Although it is Mary who enters into heaven, she takes the whole earth with her in some fashion:

> For today is heaven opened wide as it receives the Mother of Him who cannot be contained. The earth, as it yields up the Source of life, is robed in blessing and majesty. . . . Forget not, O Lady, thy ties of kinship with those who commemorate in faith the feast of thine all-holy Dormition.[79]

This has implications for the fertility of the earth. Given the strongly typological use of characters in the liturgy, this is often represented by Anna's pregnancy with Mary after her long barrenness. Imagery of nature and ground is used to contrast Anna's barrenness with the new fruitfulness made possible in Mary's birth:

> Husbandman of our thoughts and gardener of our souls, Thou hast made the barren earth fertile. Thou hast turned the ground that once was parched into fruitful land, rich in corn and bearing fruit. From holy Ann Thou hast made to blossom an undefiled fruit, the Theotokos.[80]

Here clearly eschatological imagery is implied as a restoration of fruitfulness after the experience of the barren desert.[81]

This newness of creation is envisioned in terms of beauty: "Let the creation now cast off all things old, beholding Thee the Creator made a child. For through Thy birth Thou dost shape all things afresh, making them new once more and leading them back again to their first beauty."[82] "Creation" is not always the term used: at times, the Liturgy speaks of "nature." There is no clear distinction here between "human nature" and the rest of nature. In fact, imagery that speaks of the restoration of nature in terms of a renewed paradise is employed quite often. This clearly has eschatological overtones and is not merely a "recovery" of the pre-Fall Garden, although it is often put

in the context of the world being "loosened from the ancient curse." Mary is said to turn the earth again into a paradise: "Going to dwell in the tomb, she made it a paradise. Standing beside this tomb today, we sing with joy: O ye works of the Lord, bless the Lord and exalt Him above all for ever."[83] Mary's tomb in this Feast of the Dormition recalls the cave in Bethlehem, which is repeatedly also said to restore Paradise.[84]

The phrase "bestowing salvation on all who sing thy praises" is also employed repeatedly. For example, the Irmos from the Fifth Canticle during Matins for the Annunciation, "the whole world was amazed at thy divine glory: for thou, O Virgin hast not known wedlock, hast held in thy womb the God of all, and hast given birth to an eternal Son, who rewards with salvation all who sing thy praises" (452), may seem to refer only to human "chanters." Yet, as creation is constantly affirmed to be singing God's praises (as established in the previous section), surely by implication all of creation must be included in salvation as well. One must then conclude that redemption is bestowed on all of creation (especially as the two affirmations occur within lines—or seconds—of each other). Not only does the Incarnation affirm the sanctity and goodness of material flesh as it is embraced by its creation, not only does all of creation (human and otherkind) rejoice in the liturgy and praise the Trinity, but indeed all of creation is redeemed and restored to communion with God in the Eschaton (which is already present within the liturgical celebration).

This is further confirmed by some of the Patristic homilies (although they seldom address this theme explicitly). Leontius in a *Homily on the Nativity* lists its many effects, including the restoration of Paradise and a recreation of the earth:

> Many and innumerable are the God-loving celebrations of the Christians. But what is more worthy of celebration than the present one, because Christ the Master has been born and the world has been reborn? Christ has been born and Adam has been recalled. Christ has been born and Eve has been ransomed from grief. Christ has been born and the snake has disappeared. Christ has been born and paradise has been restored. Christ has been born and the devil has been condemned. Christ has been born and Hades has been changed. Christ has been born and the earth has been recreated. Christ has been born and the air has been purified. Christ has been born and heaven has been gladdened. . . . Christ has been born and the light has been added.[85]

Christ's birth recreates and purifies the natural elements. Even hell is changed by it. Romanos also imagines some impact on the cosmos in his

hymns for Nativity: "Savior, save the world: that is why you have come. Restore your whole work: this is why you shine before me, before the wise men and before all of creation."[86] Mary is assured by Christ that she "will see me revive and renew the earth and all the children of the earth."[87] In a homily on the Annunciation, Andrew of Crete speaks of the divine plan, which includes the renewal of the universe:

> Today the Source of all authority, who made all things, brings his plan, which he worked out in advance for the creation of everything in existence, to its goal, in order that he may prevent the plan that was devised for us from the beginning by the founder of evil. For this reason angels dance, human beings rejoice, and the whole universe is renewed and restored to itself.[88]

Since human beings and the universe are here listed separately, one may safely assume that this does indeed refer to the cosmos and not only to humans.

The Dormition renders effects on the earth by far the most explicit. Andrew of Crete, in his first homily on the Dormition, suggests that Christ might renew "the whole of what he had taken from us."[89] In the third homily he describes Mary's body as "the body that has filled all creation with the fragrant myrrh of holiness." It is "the first-fruit of God's communion with his creation, of his identification, as maker of all things, with what he has made."[90] John of Damascus interprets the Dormition as sanctifying the four elements: air, water, earth, and fire (or aether):

> And what happened next? I imagine that the elements of nature were stirred up and altered, that there were sounds, crashes, rumblings, as well as remarkable hymns from angels who flew before her, providing her with an escort and with companions on the way. . . . The air, the fiery ether, the sky would have been made holy by the ascent of her spirit, as earth was sanctified by the deposition of her body. Even water had its share in the blessing: for she was washed in pure water, which did not so much cleanse her as it was itself consecrated. Then the deaf received perfect hearing again, the feet of the lame had their power to walk restored; sight was renewed in the blind, and the writ of condemnation was torn up for sinners who approached in faith.[91]

Here all the elements are sanctified, purified, made holy, and blessed by Mary's ascent. Theodore the Studite picks up on this theme of blessing and expects concrete results from it:

> O, what a radiant, brilliant festival! It is only joy that lets me speak at all! O great sign of your passing, moving us to wonder! O burial of the bearer of light, life and the gift of endless incorruption! As you rise through the clouds on your way to heaven, as you enter the holy of holies with cries of joy and praise, O Mother of God, remember to bless the bounds of this earth. By your intercession temper the air, give us rain in due season, rule over the winds, make the earth fruitful, give peace to the Church, strengthen orthodox faith, defend the Empire, ward off the barbarian tribes, protect the whole Christian people.[92]

Mary's blessing, for him, influences the weather and the fertility of the earth.

Thus the Incarnation, as celebrated in these feasts, is affirmed to have a real impact on the entire cosmos. Not only does Christ hallow human flesh and corporeality by assuming it, but he also sanctifies and renews the whole creation. Materiality and corporeality are assumed and purified by the incarnation. And nonhuman characters participate much more explicitly in these feasts than analyses of the purely human role in worship would lead us to believe. The incarnation serves to bring together earth and heaven. The divine connects itself to the material and unifies the realms of heaven and earth.

A careful analysis of the Liturgy, then, makes it absolutely incumbent upon us to treat creation as a real partner in the redemptive purposes of God. The Liturgy makes possible and works out this task of the church by including the voices of all creatures within the liturgical praise. Within the liturgy, creation is restored and glory rendered to God. The Liturgy works transformation not only for humans but for all creatures. The goodness and integrity of creation is fully affirmed within the liturgical texts. Furthermore, creation plays an active role within worship and the redemption already at work within it. If the Liturgy truly does allow the worshipping community to enter into the restored creation in God's presence and really does transform this community into what it shall be (but is only beginning to become), then care for creation must be an integral, practical, and concrete part of this transformation and mission to the world upon leaving the sacred space of the Liturgy after the celebration.